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Addiction treatment, starting at bedside

Early guidance in ERs cuts return visits; local hospitals take notice, bolster staff

By Chris Serres
GLOBE STAFF

Steven Aoki has almost no memory of how he ended up in a Mass General Brigham emergency department bed, with IV tubes attached to his body, on a September morning in 2023.

What he does remember is the excruciating abdominal pain, the nausea, and the fear that he would have to confess to doctors that his symptoms were brought on by a decade of excessive alcohol consumption — a bottle-a-day habit that was destroying his liver. “The pain was compounded by the shame of having to admit what brought me

there,” he said.

Then something unexpected happened. A physician appeared by his bedside who, to his surprise, did not scold or lecture him about his drinking habit. Instead, in a gentle voice, she offered to prescribe him a medication, Vivitrol, to treat his cravings for alcohol and to get him set up on an outpatient treatment plan — all before he was discharged.

Eighteen months later, Aoki has

not touched a drop of alcohol, an achievement he largely credits to the bedside intervention. “It literally saved my life,” said Aoki, who is 37 and lives in Charlestown.

Among the tragedies of the nation’s substance use crisis is that life-saving medicines are rarely prescribed to people with addiction even when they experience medical emergencies. Hospital emergency departments are typically reserved

ADDICTION, Page A7

‘The goal is to emphasize quality personalized care without dealing with the middleman.’

DR. DEBORAH PALMER



SUZANNE KREITER/GLOBE STAFF

Dr. Deborah Palmer checked her patient Kevin Tighe in his Holland home as part of her direct primary care practice.

A return to doctors’ house calls

New model of primary care offers convenience, communication — at a cost

By Jonathan Saltzman
GLOBE STAFF

HOLLAND — Dr. Deborah Palmer sat at the cherry wood dining room table in the home of her 71-year-old patient, trying to understand why he kept waking up in the middle of the night with a headache, indigestion, and feelings of anxiety.

The patient, Kevin Tighe, a retired businessman, recently had cardiac surgery following a heart attack. He was taking at least seven drugs, including atorvastatin for high

cholesterol.

“I’m really sick of what the drugs are doing to me,” Tighe told Palmer, his primary care doctor. “I’m sure that the reason I’m alive is because of these drugs, but it’s awful what they’re doing to me.”

Palmer took Tighe’s blood pressure, listened to his heart with a stethoscope, and discussed his feelings of depression. After spending 45 minutes with him, she kept him on his other medications but halved his dosage of atorvastatin, suspecting it was causing

the side effects.

“It’s a rough medicine for a lot of people,” she told him.

Palmer’s lengthy house call was possible as a result of an unusual career change she made in 2022 from a traditional primary care practice in Brimfield, where her roster of 3,500 patients necessitated 15-minute appointments, to an emerging model called “direct primary care.”

She now has about 200 patients who pay

DIRECT CARE, Page A7

Boston is safe. Don’t tell that to this neighborhood.



JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

Shirley Jones is the Meetinghouse Hill Civic Association president. Last year, she was startled by a fatal shooting outside her home.

Residents of historic Meetinghouse Hill say they feel ‘left behind’ as murders rise

By Dan Glaun
GLOBE STAFF

MEETINGHOUSE HILL — Shirley Jones woke up on New Year’s Day 2024 to sirens and the sight of police tape. A man had been fatally shot on her street; her neighbor had been the first to call 911.

“I get up to go for my usual walk, and it was a crime scene,” said Jones, 66, the president of the Meetinghouse Hill Civic Association, a grass-roots neighborhood advocacy group.

That shooting was one of seven last year around Meetinghouse Hill, a historic neighborhood in Dor-

chester that experienced an increase in killings in 2024 — even as Boston overall has seen dramatic reductions in its homicide rate. In all, the neighborhood of roughly 8,000 residents experienced 12.5 percent of all homicides in Boston last year. And more recently, the neighborhood was the site of another fatal shooting in January, the city’s second killing of 2025.

Boston is one of the safest big cities in the country, and today’s numbers are only a fraction of what the city saw in its darkest eras in the early 1990s, when the city counted

SHOOTINGS, Page A10

Flake; woe be gone

Monday: Wintry mix. High 41-46. low 37-42.
Tuesday: Sun pops out. High 51-56, low 34-39. Sunrise: 6:40. Sunset: 7:01.
Weather and comics, **D4-5**.
Obituaries, **C9**.

Israel widens offensive in Gaza

Considers total, long-term occupation; Palestinians once again flee attack sites

By Isabel Kershner and Hiba Yazbek
NEW YORK TIMES

JERUSALEM — Israeli forces expanded their offensive in the Gaza Strip on Sunday, taking control of more territory and issuing new evacuation orders for residents who had only recently returned to their homes.

The Israeli military renewed its offensive in Gaza this past week after talks to extend a fragile, temporary cease-fire that went into effect in mid-January reached an impasse.

Amid the escalation in fighting, Gaza’s Health Ministry said Sunday the death toll in the enclave since the war started had surpassed 50,000 people — including 39 people killed in Israeli bombardments over the past day. The ministry’s figures do not distinguish between civilians and combatants.

As Israel’s forces push back into Gaza, its political and military leaders are considering plans for a fresh ground campaign that could include a military occupation of the entire enclave for months or more.

The new and more aggressive tactics, according to current and former Israeli officials and others briefed, will probably include direct military control of humanitarian aid; targeting more of Hamas’s civilian leadership; and evacuating wom-

MIDEAST, Page A6

MBTA worst in nation for derailments

Most involve vehicles used for maintenance; officials pledge vigilance, oversight

By Shannon Larson
GLOBE STAFF

Within just a four-month period, two alarming crashes involving Green Line trains reminded commuters of the bad not-so-old days before recent upgrades to tracks and equipment notably improved ride times and the MBTA’s image.

But largely out of view was a high number of derailments of maintenance vehicles, 41 in 2024, during an intense period of construction over the last year, when the transit agency repaired and replaced decrepit tracks.

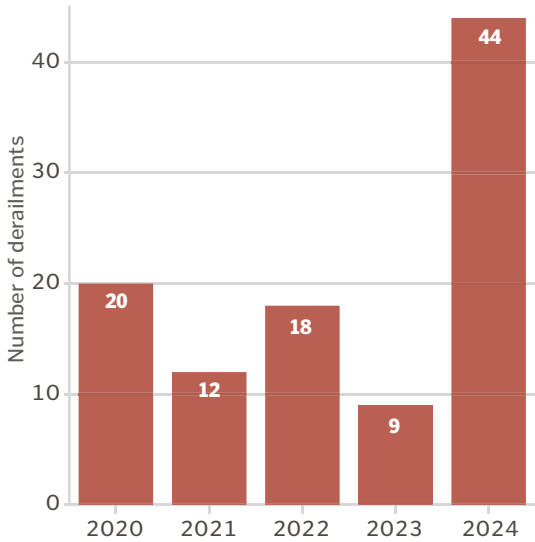
Beyond provoking yet another admonition from federal regulators over unsafe working conditions, the sheer number of incidents helped earn the MBTA a dubious distinction: it has by far the most derailments over the past five years — more than 100 — than any metro public transit systems, according to a Globe analysis of federal and T data. Nearly three-quarters of the derailments involved maintenance vehicles.

Jim Hall, a transportation specialist who chaired the National Transportation Safety Board for seven years, said the type of vehicle that derailed doesn’t matter, noting a safety risk is pre-

MBTA, Page A10

Derailments at the MBTA from 2020 through 2024

The T attributes the high number of derailments last year to extensive track repair work.



SOURCE: Federal Transit Administration, MBTA
SHANNON LARSON/GLOBE STAFF

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Pope Francis, transformed and hobbled by his bouts with pneumonia, returned to his home in the Vatican. A10.

Everett city councilors are questioning whether city taxpayers have been paying to defend Mayor Carlo DeMaria's personal interests rather than their own. B1.

The Trump administration's remov-

al of legal protections for immigrants from Cuba, Haiti, Nicaragua, and Venezuela has rocked advocates who worked to help resettle them. B1.

Canada's new leader called for federal elections next month. A4.

The Celtics, without 60 percent of their starting lineup, still prevailed over the Trail Blazers. C1.